INDIA TODAY magazine has introduced a new survey to track the attitudes of Indians towards crucial aspects of socio-economic behaviour that impact everyday lives. The results are tabulated along rural-urban and gender axes. A unique aspect of the survey is that a 'Domestic Behaviour Index' has been created that ranks Indian states across various parameters.

One set of questions aims to understand where rural/ urban people, men and women, and various states stand on diversity and discrimination. The survey asks five questions to understand how liberal/ illiberal we are on some everyday as well as critical attitudes and choices. Briefly put, the questions are: 1) whether an employer should have the right to decide not to employ a person of a certain religion; 2) should people have the freedom to choose a spouse of another religion; 3) should people have the freedom to choose a spouse of a different caste; 4) should discrimination based on food-habits be allowed and 5) comfort or lack thereof of living with neighbours from different religions.

We delve into the responses to discern if attitude shifts have occurred in recent decades. It is important to note that surveys provide us with a snapshot at a point in time and poll a limited sample; hence, they can only capture "partial truths". The word limit of an article also prevents one from deeper sociological analysis. Nevertheless, here are some observations on what the survey reveals on diversity and discrimination.

A robust 60 per cent disagree that employers should have the right to exclude people from employment based on their religion. Women, in general, show more liberal tendencies than men, although their behaviour varies state-wise. A surprising finding is that Gujarat, with its history of communal conflict, is more liberal in not discriminating against employing people based on their religion than either Tamil Nadu or Bihar. However, on most other questions, the state doesn't exactly cover itself in glory. Strangely, Haryana is more liberal than Uttar Pradesh in not discriminating on the basis of religion—perhaps because there is little representation of the minority community there, while in UP, a larger number of workers allows ease of such discrimination, likely intensified by the vitiated climate in the state.

Chandigarh delivers a cluster of counterintuitive responses. Located in the heart of the patriarchal North, it is a massive outlier with extremely liberal attitudes on inter-caste marriage and co-habitation of different religious communities. But seemingly aberrantly, it pivots when it comes to marrying across faith or across parental will. The only other question on which it bucks its progressive grain is food-based discrimination. One wonders how Le Corbusier's architecture shaped social relations so ambiguously. Perhaps we need to deepen the data with a detailed qualitative study?

The broad-brush way of understanding India as two blocs–north and south of the Vindhyas–no longer holds

On the acceptability of inter-religious and inter-caste marriages, there is all-round conservatism, with rural areas being more so than urban and women being slightly more circumspect about transgressing caste and religious boundaries to find partners; this is most likely because women in India bear the brunt of such transgressions.

Caste and ideas of purity and pollution have long governed Indians' ideas about food consumption. However, over half of the polled do not support discriminating against others on the basis of food habits, even if they involve the consumption of beef and meat. Women are a little more liberal. Among the states, Kerala and Odisha lie at two extremes, with the former completely eschewing discrimination and the latter feeling it is kosher to exclude people based on their food choices. Odisha is surprising because most states with a good mix of vegetarian and non-vegetarian diets are found to discriminate less. Among the northern states, Bihar is more liberal than southern states like Andhra Pradesh and Telangana, which favour such discrimination.

Another finding appears surprising in light of media stories of members of the minority community being denied accommodation in majority-dominated areas. The survey shows that a large section of the polled in rural and urban areas (70 per cent and 62 per cent) and an equal number of men and women are comfortable with co-residing with people of other religious communities. Among the states, men and women in Uttarakhand and MP seem to be the most intolerant while in Haryana and Rajasthan, they are much less.

One key takeaway from the survey is that the traditional broad-brush way of understanding the country as two blocs—north and south of the Vindhyas—no longer holds. The survey finds that Kerala, West Bengal and Maharashtra are ranked highest by the index on these questions while Madhya Pradesh, UP and Uttarakhand receive the lowest ranks. While the latter states can still be identified within the old BIMARU trope, the most liberal states are spread across India, with Kerala in the South, West Bengal in the East, and Maharashtra in the West. Two highlights emerging from the survey are that attitudes towards some forms of communal living testify to the decreasing importance of caste and religious discrimination, while others, as in the domain of marriage, stubbornly cling on. ■

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